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Elon Musk says he's
bringing back Vine's
archive

Elon Musk says he's bringing back Vine — sort of. The X owner [announced](#) over the weekend that the company discovered the video archive for the popular short-form video app, thought to have been deleted, and is working to restore user access.

Vine — something of a precursor to today's TikTok, but with only six-second-long looping videos — was [acquired by Twitter back in October 2012](#) for \$30 million to expand the social media platform's video ambitions. Unfortunately for Vine creators and fans, the company fumbled the app's potential and decided to [shut down Vine in 2016](#) by limiting all new uploads. The following year, it was fully discontinued, though a [user archive](#) remained for a time.

IMAGE CREDITS: TECHCRUNCH

Despite no longer having an App Store presence, Vine still has a place in the internet's collective cultural consciousness. Through online compilations of the best Vines uploaded to YouTube, and through the careers of numerous creators who got their start on Vine, the company lives on to some extent, and its content continues to be discovered by new generations.

Musk himself seemed interested in bringing back Vine after [acquiring Twitter in October 2022](#). In a [poll posted](#) on the social media app, he asked Twitter's users, "Bring back Vine?" to which nearly 70% responded "yes." [Axios reported at the time](#)

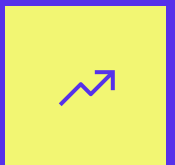
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that Twitter had devoted some engineers to working on the Vine reboot, but nothing ever came of it.



Elon Musk  
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Grok Imagine is AI Vine!

Btw, we recently found the Vine video archive (thought it had been deleted) and are working on restoring user access, so you can post them if you want.

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It's unclear whether Musk has any ambitions for Vine beyond getting its archive back online, however. In the same post about restoring Vine, he also touted that Grok's new video-creation feature, Grok Imagine, also available to X Premium+ subscribers, is "AI Vine." That suggests that his interests in video creation no longer lie with human creativity, but in human-directed AI prompting.

Whether or not Musk will actually deliver on the promise remains to be seen, as the X post could have just been another way to draw attention to Grok AI, rather than being representative of a real effort inside the company to make old Vines available for reposting.

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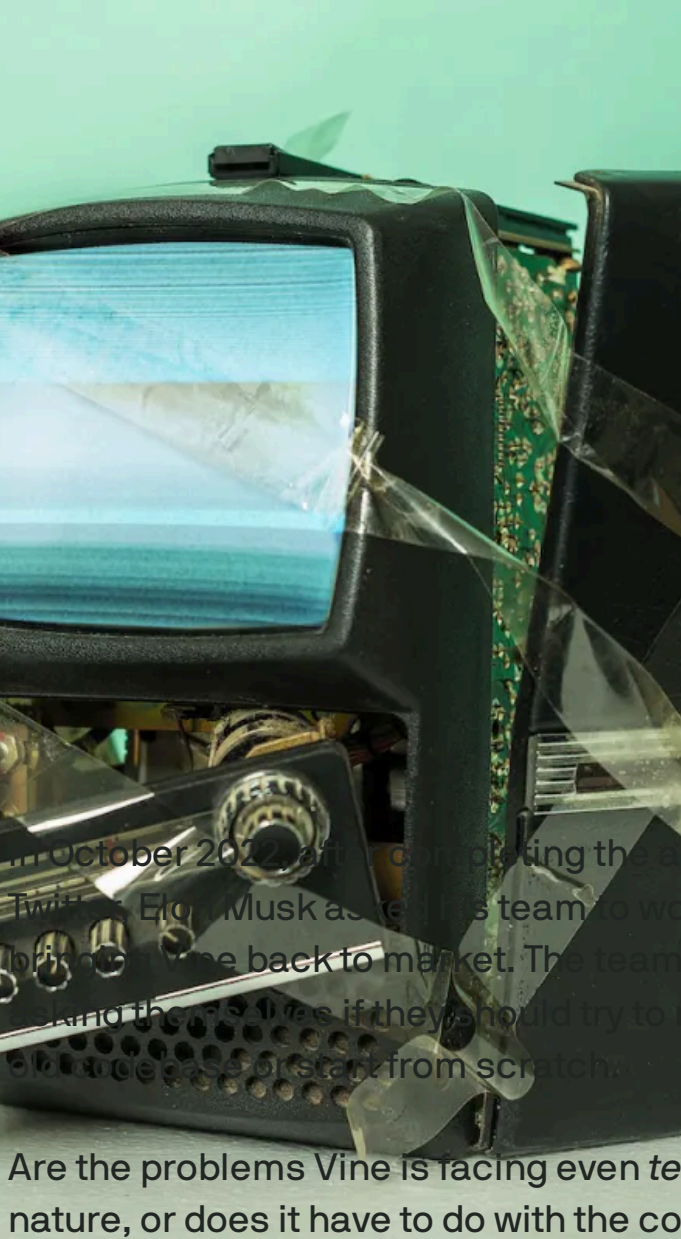
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A Vine mess: The choice between rebooting and reviving old software

Marcus Merrell — 9:30 AM PST · February 1, 2023

In October 2022, after completing the acquisition of Twitter, Elon Musk asked his team to work toward bringing Vine back to market. The team is likely now asking the question if they should try to revive the app or start from scratch.

Are the problems Vine is facing even *technical* in nature, or does it have to do with the core business model? IMAGE CREDITS: [KORON](#) / GETTY IMAGES

I have no actual knowledge of the Vine tech stack, but these questions (as we'll see) have been a constant in the industry for well over 20 years. This article uses my own experience working on high-throughput B2B and B2C stacks during a similar time period that Vine was around, and I'm making some assumptions.

Whether I'm correct or not, the broader considerations will apply to anyone facing such a decision right now.

The trouble with Vine

The trouble facing Vine has nothing to do with its tech. It's likely that the team at Twitter could define

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and ship a perfectly designed app and not even make a dent in TikTok's market share.

The conversation they should be having is more about business than technology. When Vine launched in 2012, TikTok was still five years away, and Vine never figured out how to monetize its platform successfully in a way that took care of the top creators and influencers. It might be ambitious to think that you can go from zero to a world-class social media site in a matter of months.

Whether the team chooses to reboot or revive Vine, they must answer questions about sustaining a business in the world the app abandoned in 2016.



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For Vine, this is a business decision, but it's being treated like it's a technical decision. By choosing to reboot from scratch, you're letting software developers decide your business strategy, and that approach risks losing the market.

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With that in mind, let's simplify this a bit:

Companies face such questions pretty frequently, so what are the non-business considerations that should be factored in?

Revive or reboot?

Let's pretend that Musk and his team have solved the business problems or at least become comfortable enough with their ideas that they've tasked you with the choice: Revive or reboot? How do you proceed?

I'm indebted to Joel Spolsky for [his April 2000 article](#) on the subject. A lot has changed since the time that blog was written: The world was pre-agile, pre-cloud, and pre-continuous-integration. Vine itself is probably showing its age as well. It launched in 2012, which means it was likely using REST APIs, which means it was pre-container, pre-gRPC and pre-Kafka. If they did data streaming at all, it was likely built in-house. Some former Vine engineers [have already said it needs to be rewritten](#).

But Spolsky's points remain as salient today as when Bill Clinton was president:

The market will not pause and wait for you to get it right.

It's bold to think you'll do everything perfectly (or even better) this time around.

The architectural problems with any codebase can be fixed slowly, over time, in a careful and mindful way.

Migrating a product from monolith to microservices is a great way to modernize a tech stack.

Microservices are well suited to iterative improvements while minimizing disruption.

A common analogy

Reviving parts of a codebase is like changing a plane’s engine while it’s mid-flight. But the key is that the plane is in flight — it’s moving forward along its path. If you start from scratch, the plane is in the hangar while your competitors continue sailing across the ocean, picking up market share in the space you vacated.

Vine has already spent six years in the hangar. Rebooting will only guarantee that it stays there longer.

When you reboot, you either have a separate team keeping your old product alive and supported — doubling (or tripling) the cost of development — or you put everyone on the reboot, only fixing critical bugs in the old product as needed.

In both cases, you’re wasting time and resources. Musk doesn’t have to worry about keeping the old stack “in flight,” but that’s a rare exception, and he is still losing market share every day.

My own experience with rebooting

I’ve been involved in two “reboot” projects and three “revive” projects.

The reboots were both B2B, at boutique software firms that took an infusion of cash to rewrite the products. The “revive” projects were both B2B and B2C, and kept their cash flow high throughout.

Reboots

The reboot projects were great for learning the fundamentals of programming: how to build

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Revivals

The “revive” projects I’ve been on have been far more difficult, but I wouldn’t say I learned any less. What you learn and how you learn it will be radically different from a reboot project, but it will help you better understand how to troubleshoot, do root-cause analysis and make a system robust. If you’re keen, you’ll also learn a lot about internal politics, consensus building and diplomacy.

Refactoring a critical system to use microservices and cloud architecture while minimizing downtime and keeping customers happy will look dynamite on any résumé. It will show your future employers that you’re versatile, resourceful and patient. I’d argue that those are more important traits for a long-term career than the ability to create a new project from a blank slate.

The inevitable difficulties of reviving

Of course, it will be difficult to take out the old code, dust it off and make it scalable for 2023. It's going to be easier to write new code than to understand and fix old code.

But the stuff you hate about that old code is exactly what makes it work. The parts that are ugly represent bug fixes not incompetencies. If there's something in the codebase you don't like, write a few unit tests, make sure they pass, then make the code look how you want it to before you run the unit tests again. Then add some comments.

This preserves the functionality of the feature and gives you confidence and understanding that it'll be easier to deal with in the future. It also gives you a feeling of ownership.

However, people like to assume that if there's something they don't understand, it's useless. In reality, it may indicate a fix for an esoteric edge case that was important enough to address (even if it could have been documented better).

Here's how to face these challenges:

Write some unit tests, making sure you turn the questionable lines green.

Write some comments indicating your questions about the code.

Leave all that there until you (or someone else) need to revisit it.

If that day never comes, then the code is doing its job superbly.

But what if you just can't see a way to revive in any reasonable timeline?

Not invented here

There are some advantages to rebooting if you decide that all the previous considerations don't apply:

It's cloud native, scalable and purpose-built for fleet management.

A reboot utilizes all the best modern software development practices from the beginning: unit testing, accessibility, security and performance can all be locked up.

There's a brand new SDLC pipeline, where developers can deploy to production per-commit, using feature flagging and canary builds to limit the blast radius of any issues.

A/B experimentation and new-user analytics can be utilized from day one, giving you guaranteed signals for conversion lift, engagement and more.

Surely you won't make any mistakes this time, right?

Everything listed here is months' worth of work, and nothing listed here has anything to do with your core business. Like it or not, the challenges of the core business will continue to be the hardest piece of the puzzle.

In Vine's case, its core business code has already been written once. Even if you have to abandon everything else, at least keep those bits of operable code that represent the real engine behind the platform.

Conclusion

Of course, I could be wrong. I'm sure rebooting has been viable in some cases (though none come to mind). I can imagine it working if they take the finest architects from their social, content and

infrastructure management divisions and let them draw up the plans, which would then be implemented by a new team.

If it were that easy, though, nothing would stop another company from doing the same thing. That's how dependent they are on the brand memory of Vine — they assume that throwing together something brand new with the right logo will fix their problems.

I'd wager that the tech is the least of their problems.

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Vine is shutting down, so don't forget to export your videos today

Sarah Perez — 9:01 AM PST · January 17, 2017

As [first announced back in October](#), Twitter is about to shut down its looping video app and social network, Vine. The company had originally implied it would pull the Vine app from the app stores, but later said it would [transition it to a new, low-maintenance app](#) called Vine Camera instead.

Ahead of this, Vine's website and app were updated to allow you to export your Vines for posterity, if you couldn't bear to lose them.

Vines can be exported until some point today from the vine.co website, or from the iOS or Android application. The Vine website currently says you can download your Vines "only until January 17, when the apps become the Vine Camera," but the mobile app's banner says the app will actually be updated tomorrow.

In any event, you have only hours left to grab your Vines before they're gone.

To begin the process from the app, you'll need to look for the button "Save Vines" on your Profile

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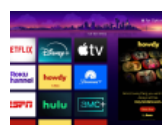
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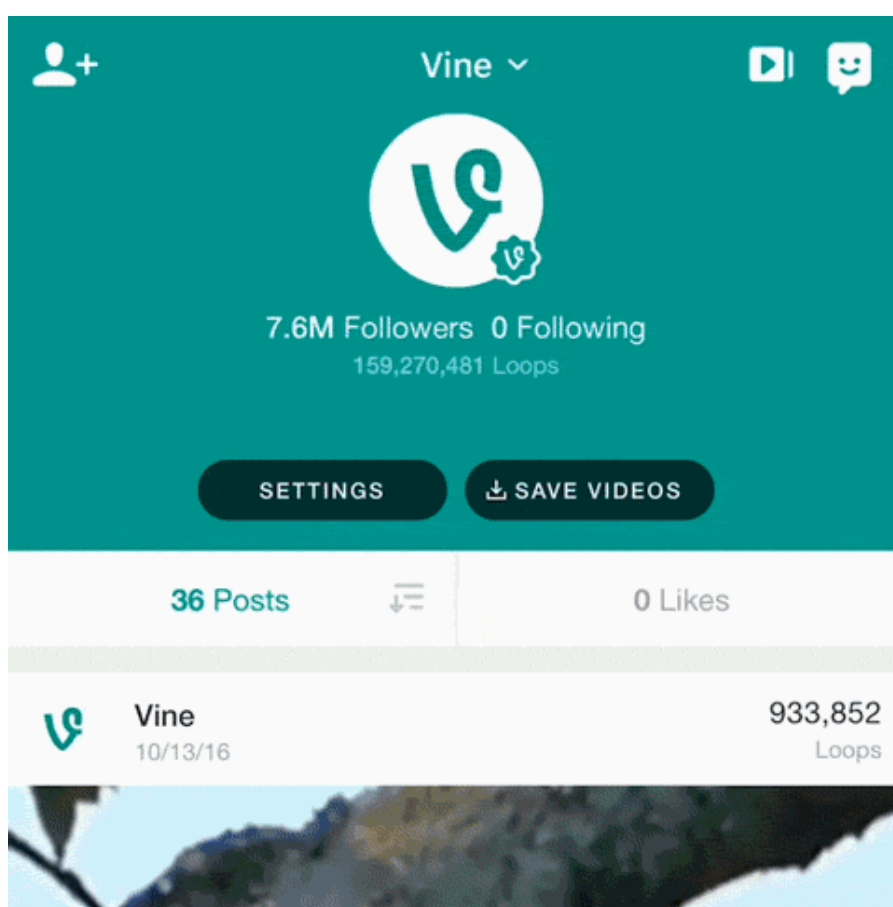
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page which will export the Vines to your Camera Roll. If you choose to instead get a download link, you can save the data referencing your videos' Likes and reposts, too.



Another alternative is to use Giphy to turn your past Vines into GIFs. Shortly after the announcement of Vine's closure in October, [Giphy debuted its own conversion tool](#) that exports your Vines and can be used to save them on Giphy's site. Of course, GIFs don't have sound, and Vines do – so [Giphy's tool](#) will download the videos and sound files separately. This could work for those Vines that are more visual, but don't necessarily need the audio track to make sense.

It's unclear exactly when Vine's app will be updated on the app stores today, but we're down to the final hours at this point.

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Vine, which was once a vibrant social network capable of producing its own stars, and [a top-rated social app](#), will then transform into a more basic utility. [The new Vine Camera](#) will simply allow you to record 6-second looping videos, but there will no longer be a community where these can be shared.

For a service that once had more than 200 million active users, Vine's demise speaks to Twitter's inability to capitalize on the technology and network it acquired back in 2012. The company missed opportunities to deeply integrate Vine into Twitter, similar to how Instagram uses its feeder apps Boomerang, Layout and Hyperloop to help users create engaging content. By allowing Vine's social network to establish itself as a separate entity from Twitter's, the company also missed the opportunity to bring more people to Twitter's platform and increase engagement among existing users.

Vine also faced issues with bots, as does Twitter, and didn't offer an easy way for creators to make money, compared with other video platforms, like YouTube.

The closure had sparked some anger and sadness among users, but also from Vine founder Rus Yusupov [who tweeted about Vine’s death](#), with a reminder to other founders: “don’t sell your company!”

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